

AURUMGLATHROLOS ADVENTURE:

Once the group decides to travel to the Nether mountains and find Aurum's lair, they begin to learn many things about the region. The mountains have long resisted attempts at civilization and have been known to harbor various evil humanoid bands and contain many bandit holds. Although no villages or town's are known to exist in the mountains, rumours tell of an ancient temple to a forgotten deity nestled somewhere within the peaks. Although the rumours vary from tale to tale, the one thing they share in common is that the temple was dedicated to a god or demon of ancient evil and is said to be a gateway to a dark, nether-hell. It is also rumored that a clan of Harpies makes its aerie high upon one of the mountain slopes guarding some ancient tomb or ruins.

Adventure background:

Once the group heads into the mountains they will find the weather very cold and the mountain terrain very cold and unforgiving. As they travel across the mountain range one of the characters should spot a series of ruins upon one of the highest peaks around. The ruins house the remains of an ancient temple dedicated to a very powerful and ancient demon/Tanar'ri known as "Horgrathix". Horgrathix was said to be a Balor of incredible strength and power. It is said that his darkest desire was to rule a world full of living slaves, that he could torture for all eternity. His goal was almost completed when his faithful followers upon ancient Toril raised his powerful temple, and began the ceremony to bring Horgrathix fully into the world of men. However many creatures of good did not wish to become food for Horgrathix and joined forces with powerful allies, namely Mystrl the goddess of Magic, to combat and eventually imprison Horgrathix in a state of flux, or in between worlds. If any creature were to break the mystical bonds that bind his temple doorway, they Horgrathix would be able to step from between worlds and fully enter Toril. The only thing that can prevent this is a powerful "re-sealing" or Holy spell that would sanctify and purify the gateway once again. Hopefully the characters realize that to open the doorway would be very bad and try to find another way down the mountain. If the characters do not realize the mistake of opening the doorway, then they will be releasing one of the most powerful and evil creatures that ever lived. They would most likely be killed, since none of the characters has any weapon of enough power to hurt Horgrathix.

Once the characters are moving again, they will eventually find the bloody remains of several Harpies scattered across the mountain side. Further investigation will reveal that the harpies had been slain with both magic and weapons. If the group manages to do some extraordinary tracking checks, they should be able to find the remains of the harpies aerie. Once they begin to search around they find more harpie bodies, numbering around 45 total. Yet the group find no signs of who killed the harpies and find almost no treasure, unless they look very hard for at least an hour. The only clues they find are that the harpies died by various spells and blades. A difficult spellcraft role should reveal some of the different types of spell's used.

Unknown to the characters the evil group of adventures that has been one step ahead of them since the Tower of Chimes, has been through this area already, and is also seeking the lair of Aurum. The group known as "The Company of the Crimson Claw", are devout followers of Rothexilldraxus or better known as Rothex the Red. Rothex has been fuming for over 300 years after his defeat at the town of Silverymoon. That the city has become such a beacon of law and order in the north, has fueled his anger even further. Rothex knows that if he had taken Silverymoon those 300 years past, then he would be ruling a vast empire that stretched across the known north. But due to the intervention of a few unknown adventures and the appearance of an ancient elven artifact, his plans were thwarted and his empire was never realized. But during the last 300 years, Rothex has had time to think things through and come up with a new plan. The Company of the Crimson Claw, is just one group of many that Rothex uses to further his evil goals in the north.

Rothex learned, over 200 years ago, that an ancient family of Bronze Dragons had a lair deep within the southern Nether mountain range. This was very odd to Rothex because he never saw the creatures venture forth from their lair. Rothex knew his bronze cousins liked the ocean as much as a white dragon loved the frozen north and suspected that something was amiss. During his researches and

plundering of various pools of knowledge across the north, he found reference to an ancient gateway built by giants of ages past. During the age when giants ruled an empire, he found reference of a gateway that could send creatures of dragon size across vast distances of the known giant empire. Locations of the gateway's were lost, but one thing that Rothex found was that there was a main gateway that powered all the others and that if you controlled it, you controlled access to a number of gateway's linked across the northern and southern continents. With this kind of access, Rothex could expand his influence and conquer lands that he could not even reach with a day's worth of flying. Rothex has been searching for over a hundred years before he found the answer that he was looking for. While hunting afar, along the sword coast, he came upon a young bronze dragon hunting along the coast. He ambushed the young dragon, captured and tortured it and finally found the answer he was seeking. The ancient bronze dragon, Aurumglathrolas, was the last of his line and was guarding the "Arch of Giants". This was how Aurum and his kin were able to travel to their beloved oceans, without being seen leaving their lair. However, over the years, Aurum's kin had left the caverns and only Aurum himself was left. Although Rothex was a very cunning and powerful dragon, he did not wish to fight Aurum on equal terms. So he hired groups of men and other creatures to attack and harass any who would or could aid Aurum in any way. With most of this accomplished, Rothex is now sending his most powerful followers into the mountains to find Aurum's lair and kill him if possible. If his servants fail, hopefully they will at least weaken Aurum so that Rothex will be able to fight him with a greater advantage.

Once the group finds Aurum's lair and speaks to the great bronze wyrm, he will tell them about his plight and how he is the last of his line. He will not ask the group to help him, but hope that they will offer to help on their own. He will explain to them the importance of protecting the Giant's Arch and not letting it fall into the hands of Rothex, or any other creature of evil. He will emphasize that the Arch should be destroyed before it falls into any such creature's hands. Whether or not the group agrees to help, the ceremony of bonding should take place and Shannon's character, Galin, should accept the mantle of Dragon disciple. Once the ceremony ends, Aurum gives the characters a portable hole, which he fills with random treasure from his hoard. However, as soon as he gives the characters the portable hole, his wards and spells go off, and he learns that the Company of the Crimson Claw has found his lair. Without your help, he will be sorely weakened. He asks the group's help in defeating the evil raiders, hopefully the characters agree and prepare to beat back the Crimson Claw's assault. While the characters are preparing, Aurum telepathically links to Galin and tells him that the Giant's Arch has two command words, one to open a gateway "Hortul" and another to close it "Lutroh". Aurum does not have time to explain how you choose where you wish the gate to open to, only that the Giant's arch was designed to create gateway's across the ancient Giant empire.

So saying, the battle begins with the Crimson Claw's throwing numerous raised undead and summoned creatures into the forefront to weaken the dragon. They have no knowledge of the characters being present and it could definitely work against them if the group was to surprise them. Aurum acts as bait and draws the Claw's out into the open where, hopefully, the characters are able to ambush them and do a significant amount of damage. Unbeknownst to the characters, or to Aurum, Rothex does not wish for the battle to end and enters the melee on the fifth round of combat. Aurum, already weakened by the battle with the Claw's, knows that he cannot defeat Rothex and survive. He telepathically calls to the group and tells them to use the gate to flee through. He tells them that he will hold off Rothex long enough to allow them a chance to escape and then activate his guarding wards and seal his lair off forever. Hopefully the group manages to make it through the gate, but right before they do Aurum sends a telepathic message to Shannon's character only telling him when they get to the other side of the gate, they must not close it immediately, but wait until the time is right, you will know when it is time. Hopefully Shannon's character heeds Aurum's advice and waits for a while. Not long after the characters step through they are shocked to see Rothex's head poke through the gate, and begin to come through. Shannon's character should then realize that this is the right time and say the word, "Lutroh", and close the gate. The sudden closure of the gate tears Rothex's body in two and slays the ancient worm forever.

After such a harrowing experience, the group will decide that they need to rest and recuperate, but will not have the opportunity. As they watch the last death throes of Rothex, a new problem confronts them. Towering over them, at almost 20 feet tall, are several Giants wearing armor and carrying huge morningstars. Needless to say a giant-sized castle rises up in the background.

Evil NPC's information:

"The Company of the Crimson Claw" (20 members)

- 1) Priest of Talos, 9th level, Human male, Exp-2,000
- 2) Priestess of Loviatar, 8th level, Human female exp-1,600
- 3) Cult of the dragon Sorcerer, 7th level, human male exp-1,600
- 4) Cult of the dragon Wizard, 8th level, 1/2 drow male exp-1,500
- 5) Wizard specialist (summoner), 7th level, human male exp-1,220
- 6) Rogue, 9th level, half/orc male exp-1340
- 7) Rogue, 5th level, human male, exp-995
- 8) Hill Giant warrior, 8th level, male exp-2,500
- 9) Fire Giant Shaman, 6th level, male exp-2,200
- 10) Flind Warriors (5), 5th level, males exp-300 each
- 11) Ogre Magi, 6th level, male, exp-3,200
- 12) Ogre bodyguards, 4th level, males (2) exp- 500 each
- 13) Half-Dragon/HalfOgre (Red), 7th level warrior exp- 1,700
- 14) Duergar Warrior, 7th level, female exp-1,650
- 15) Drow Priestess/Sorceress, 8/5th levels, female exp- 1,900

Experience for the slain dragon, Rothex the Red- 45,000exp